

1947–1955

THE NEW LOOK

Two years after the end of World War II, French haute couture designer Christian Dior introduced the New Look. The silhouette he defined had had its beginnings in the late 1930s, but during the war its development was put on hold until couturiers started showing again in 1944. Other designers were also working on similar skirt shapes but the fashion media credited Dior with the inception of the New Look. Dior's collection – his first – marked a change from the shapes of the previous decade. Before and during the war a square-shouldered and boxy utility suit, which saved on fabrics during rationing, was prominent. The New Look collection, launched in February 1947, included rounded or sloped shoulders; a tiny, nipped-in waist (achieved via a short corset and other undergarments); padded and rounded hips; and a very full skirt with heavy pleating. Extra fabric and a petticoat helped create the skirt's fullness.

Demure dressing

French couturier Jacques Heim designed this New Look-inspired dress in 1950. Less flamboyant than his colleagues, Heim designed couture that was both utilitarian and ladylike for clients. He also launched a line aimed specifically at a younger clientele.



1950

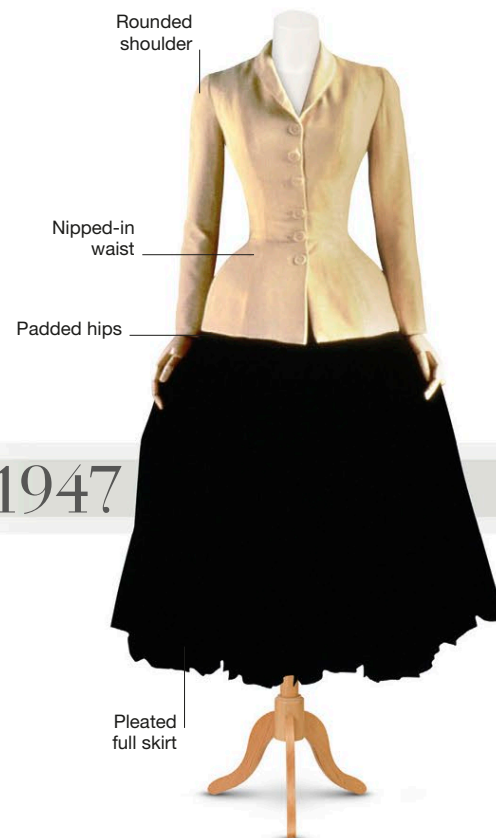
NEW LOOK UNDERWEAR

Those re-creating the New Look style utilized separate undergarments to create the ideal silhouette. Short corsets, girdles, brassieres, or waist cinchers proved to be the basis of fashions during this period and helped women to achieve this hyper-feminine look.

The Spencer "Spen-support"



1947



New Look defined The design that started it all, this *Bar Suit* of 1947 by Dior defined the silhouette of the 1950s. Carmel Snow, American editor of *Harper's Bazaar*, called the collection the "New Look" and the name stuck.

1952



American daywear This 1950s shirtwaist day dress from Los Angeles was like those typically worn by the American housewife. It is of simple red and white cotton gingham, and includes a plastic belt and a necktie of matching fabric.

Luxury fabric Dior's New Look collection of 1947 also included *Chérie*, this blue silk taffeta dinner dress. The skirt is made of a full width of fabric, from selvage to selvage, much of which is used to pad the hips.